

The reality stack

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A stack is layers where each one rests on the one below — like a tech stack in computing, rock strata in geology or floors in a building. The reality stack exists to turn “is this just the way things are?” into “which layer does this object sit at, and therefore how contingent, how mutable, and how accountable is it?” It is not original metaphysics — it is a teaching device, descriptive in form but normatively motivated: it exists to make a particular claim about inequality arguable.

Three layers and a cross-section

The **physical layer** is invariant law. Gravity, thermodynamics, the speed of light. You cannot negotiate with it. It gives rise to everything above but does not determine it.

The **material layer** is the physical world in the mode of human encounter: bodies, biology, climate, geography, and the infrastructure we have built into it. Not philosophical materialism — physics considered through the lens of what humans need, what they are stuck with, and what they have made. The calorie requirement of a body; the fact that there is a river here and not there; the concrete your city is made of.

The **social layer** is the constructed layer — arrangements humans make collectively, constrained by the material but not determined by it. Two societies with identical material conditions can organise themselves in opposite ways, and historically have, sometimes apparently on purpose. It is where power, roles, norms, and institutions live — and it is the layer people tend to mistake for one of the layers below. Which side of the road you drive on, marriage, money.

The **agent** is not a fourth layer but a cross-section — a single point where all three meet. An agent has a physical body, material needs, and a social layer carried inside as language, shame, politeness. What is purely agent? Very little — a flinch, a heartbeat, a refusal. And yet the cross-section is the only site from which any of it can be questioned. Agents, acting together, reshape the social, which reshapes the material, which reshapes what is possible.

Locating a thing

To test where a thing sits, ask: *if the other layers were varied independently, would this thing vary with them, or hold constant?* Gravity holds across all societies and all bodies — physical. The calorie requirement of a body holds across all societies but varies across species — material. Which side of the road cars drive on varies across societies within identical material conditions — social.

The test is not a decision procedure. Many interesting cases — gender, race, disease, addiction — pass it ambiguously, and that is the point: the framework surfaces the dispute rather than resolves it. Where the layer-assignment is contested, it names the contest. That is less than a theory and more than a vibe.

We are suspicious of the word **natural** because it often does covert work — moving a social claim down to the physical layer, where it can no longer be argued with. “Hierarchy is natural” makes hierarchy a law of gravity. “It is human nature to be selfish” puts a collective behaviour on the physical layer despite massive anthropological evidence to the contrary. The word has legitimate uses — naturalistic ethics, evolutionary biology use it without sleight of hand. The suspicion is of the rhetorical move, not the word. It is a way to escape accountability by crossing into a layer where accountability does not apply.

Three spectrums run through the stack, related but not interchangeable. **Contingency** — whether something could have been otherwise; zero at the physical layer, some at the material, a great deal at the social. **Mutability** — how readily it can be changed; you cannot change gravity, material conditions take generations, social arrangements change in a lifetime, an agent's position in a moment. **Accountability** — not “who caused it” but “who, going forward, is situated to change it.” A thing can be contingent and mutable and yet have no locatable individual at fault; responsibility can be collective and forward-looking even when no individual chose the outcome. Contingency is the descriptive axis, mutability the practical, accountability the normative. They come apart, and the interesting political arguments are always about which axis a dispute is on.

So when you catch yourself asking “is this just the way things are?” — locate the thing in the stack. If it sits at the physical layer, accept it. If it sits anywhere above, the question has an answer: it is this way because of the layer it sits at, the path it took, and the feedback that locked it in. None of that is destiny. That is the whole point of naming the layers.